Early Rank-Order Continuity Is Modest, Not Destiny

Personality and temperament show modest rank-order consistency in early childhood that increases with age; a three-year-old's relative standing is not adult personality.

ERATE-TO-HIGH-PATTERN; LOW-INDIVIDUAL-FORECAST | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: DEVELOPMENT, TEMPERAMENT | REPLICATI

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Individual differences persist somewhat. They do not lock. Roberts & DelVecchio (2000) meta-analyzed 152 longitudinal studies (3,217 test–retest correlations) of personality trait rank-order consistency from childhood through old age. Consistency is an increasing function of age. The childhood interval is modest (population estimate about r = .31 for birth to 2.9 years), far below later-adulthood estimates.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

This is a quantitative review of test–retest r, not an RCT of "early personality." Measurement changes across ages (heterotypic continuity). The existing temperament card (temperament-reactivity-not-destiny.md) is about dimensional structure, not this age function. Adjacent: Watts delay is a different overclaim (marshmallow as school-success law).

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

An early-childhood r near .3 leaves most variance in relative standing open to later reallocation. Stability coefficients typically rise after early childhood; that rise is not proof that age three was already the adult trait.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (meta-analytic psychometric test-retest stability, not a causal exposure).

Western, questionnaire-heavy samples are common. Informant and interval length affect r. Extreme-tail trajectories can be more persistent than the population average without becoming destiny.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Age three does not determine adulthood. Moderate continuity is not a license to ignore early difficulty, and it is not a license to treat a toddler's standing as a finished self.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Treat early differences as probabilities that still move. Ranking children by a three-year-old trait score does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Roberts & DelVecchio (2000), Psychological Bulletin